

How We Tested

Test Machine Configuration

Processor: AMD 64 3800+**Memory:** 512 MB DDR 400**HDD:** Seagate 7200.8 120 GB SATA**OS:** Windows XP Professional SP 2

We used Adobe Acrobat 8.0 for the PDF (combination test) and Adobe Photoshop CS2 for the photo printout.

Before the printers were tested, we calibrated each of them using the toolbox utility that is built into all printer drivers these days. First, the cartridges were cleaned (by the utility), then they were aligned. Only after we were satisfied with a couple of test prints did the testing commence.

Performance Parameters

1. Speed
2. Quality

Test Documents

Text Only: monochrome text in different font sizes

Combi Document: a PDF file consisting of text at different font sizes, a reverse text test (yellow text on a black background) at varied font sizes, an embedded photograph, a colour chart, and a pie diagram, with lines to check for aliasing

Photo Test: our test photo consisted of eight individual scenes. Each of these had something to test the individual parameters that collectively make for great photo printouts.

The Speed Tests

All the tests were carried out with A4 size sheets. We used the “click-to-clunk” method to time the printouts, which essentially means we measured the time period between the moment at which we hit “Print” to the moment at which the printout was thrown out of the printer.



For the speed tests, we used all three types of documents at two printer settings—Low and High quality. For the Text and Combination documents, we used Executive Bond Paper, while for the photo printout, we used 150 gsm Kodak glossy photo paper.

The Quality Tests

In addition to the already printed pages, we also printed a Word document with a line of text printed with font sizes

ranging from 2 to 12 at Best Quality. We examined this printed text for clarity, smudging and skewing, at all font sizes. We also looked for aliasing, which is the occurrence of jagged edges around the edges of the fonts.

Similarly, we also examined the printout of the PDF file. Here, we noted things such as the colour tone and clarity of the small photograph, discrete reproduction of concentric circles, and yellow text against black background. The combination document also had a basket of fruit, which we studied for detailing and highlights as well as for texturing.

In the photograph, we first looked at the overall colour tone. We examined details such as reproduction of correct skin tone, discreteness in the hair, colour variation in flowers and fruit, discrete bands of colour and greyscale in colour charts, and solder points on the circuit board. We also looked at highlighting on the metal flask and glass jars (specular highlights) as well as detailing on the golf balls (the dimples).

Canon Pixma iP 5300

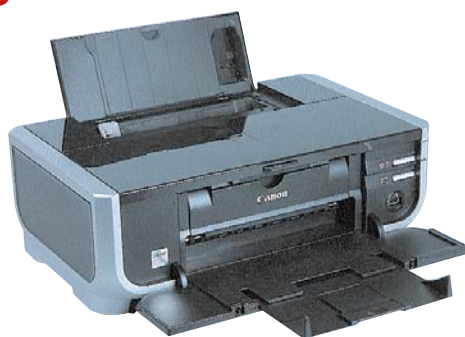
World-class photo prints

One look at the iP5300 is all that's necessary to confirm its status as a high-end product. It's finished in translucent black with opaque silver-grey around the corners. The angular corners are deliberate and add to the aggressive tone the iP5300 sets. Build quality, needless to say, is very good—leagues ahead of its lesser siblings.

The output tray is accessible via a push-button system; very classy-looking and works well.

Positioned by Canon as a dedicated A4 photo printer, one look tells us where the iP5300 is most comfortable. It uses a pigment-based five-colour individual ink-tank system and supports printing on a variety of media, including CDs and DVDs. PictBridge, a must for any photo printer, is available.

One of the little features we liked (common with the iP3300) is



the red ink-tank bay LEDs. Once you slot in a cartridge the corresponding LED lights up. If you installed it incorrectly (which is very difficult to achieve), the LED will not illuminate. These LEDs also turn on when the service flap (on the top of the printer, allowing access to the cartridge bay) is opened. This makes the task of installation of cartridges even easier.

The iP5300 is a printer that doesn't like to keep its patrons waiting—prints are completed fast, just the way you like it! Text

quality was exemplary; not that we expected anything less for its price. However, as the Epson R390 proved, nothing should be taken for granted! We noticed that quality in text output didn't come at draft settings, and the D4168 does better when on a diet. Our combination document looked good, especially the reverse text and the tiny fonts, which were ultra-readable—this printer was *numero uno* here. Highlighting on the fruit was also reasonably well done, second to the brilliant (in this aspect at least) D4168.

One look at the test photo printed on the iP5300 tells you where this printer's heart lies. Good colour reproduction in general was complemented with excellent contrast and specular highlights. The highlights on the steel flask looked real, as did the shimmering effect on the glass aquarium. Even the leather handbag felt very substantial. For those looking for a great photo printer, look no further than the Pixma iP5300, which retails at Rs 12,995.